

Developing Applications Using Node.js

JavaScript has been a popular language for Web development, but it was restricted to the browser. Node.js takes a step beyond and uses JavaScript for shell scripting, server side scripting and more. This article gets you started with the Node development environment.



Node.js allows developers to build applications using their favourite JavaScript language. Though there is extensive add-on software built on Node for Web development, it is not restricted. You can also develop command line utilities, standalone applications and server-based software using Node.

Node consists of two main components - the JavaScript engine and the Web server. The JavaScript engine is a high performance, finely tuned Google V8 engine. A Web server embedded in Node makes it attractive for developing applications for HTTP clients such as browsers.

Node takes JavaScript to a new dimension by adding the file system access functionality. Such functionality was not available in JavaScript, as it was restricted to running in the browser sandbox.

Installing Node

Node.js is available as pre-compiled binaries on all popular platforms such as Windows, Mac, and Linux. Installation on the respective platforms is simple with a wizard style installer.

On Mac and Linux operating systems, Node.js gets installed in the `/usr/local/bin` directory.

To check the installation, run the following command:

```
$ node --version
$ node
>
```

Command line Node

Node allows evaluation of JavaScript expressions and code at the prompt. This feature is very handy if you are learning the basics of JavaScript.

```
$ node
a = 10
10
> console.log("Value of a = "+a)
Value of a = 10
undefined
> (Ctrl+C twice or ".exit" to quit prompt)
```